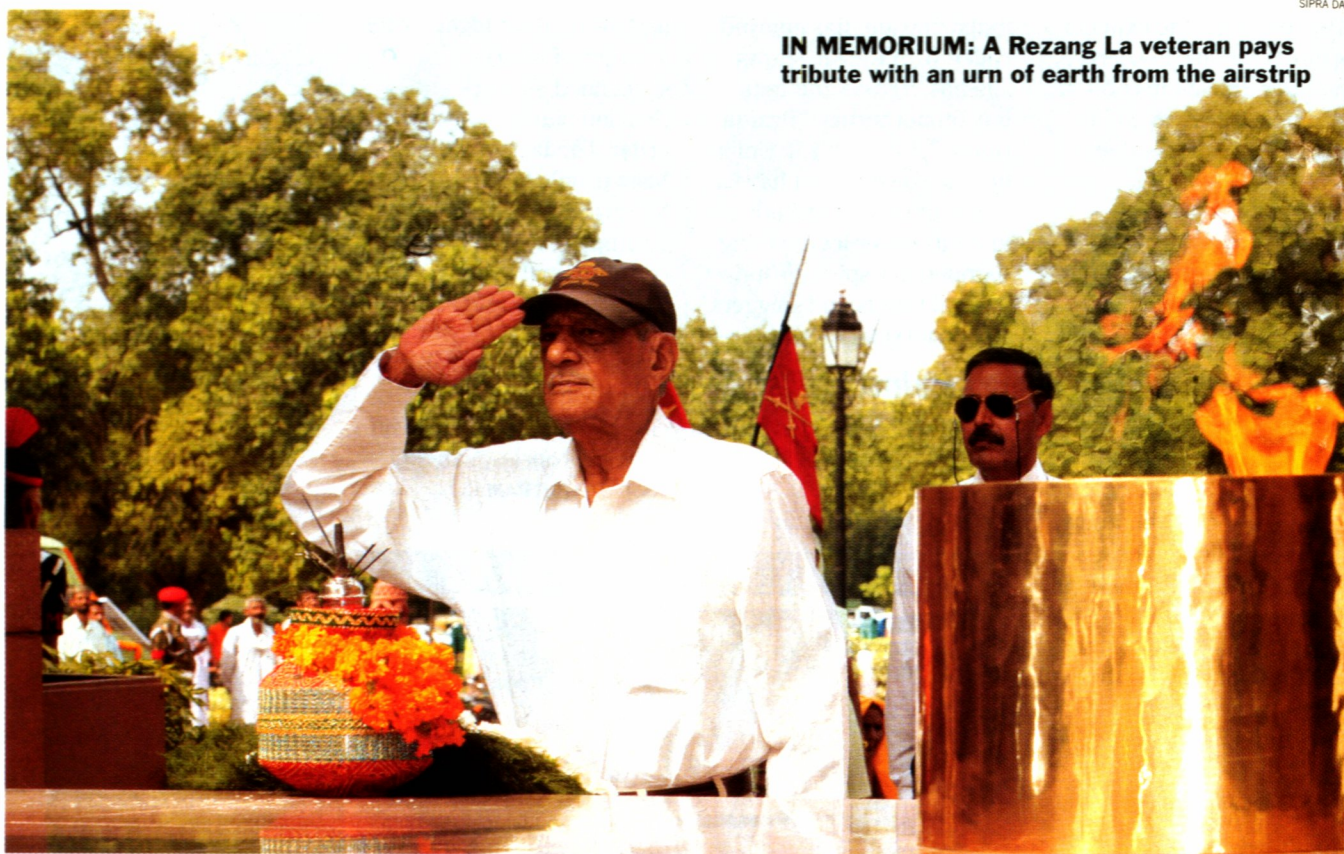


IN MEMORIUM: A Rezang La veteran pays tribute with an urn of earth from the airstrip



The Soil Tells its Story

Survivors bring home a small corner of the battlefield where more than 100 comrades perished

■ **By Shyamlal Yadav**

"I feel younger these days", says Phul Singh Yadav, honorary captain (retd) of Indian Army's 13 battalion of Kumaon Regiment. The septuagenarian adds, "I remember vividly the battle of Rezang La and the bravery of fellow soldiers who gave their lives for the nation." Out of a total of 124 soldiers, deployed to defend the highest airstrip in the world from the Chinese in 1962, only 10 came back alive. But before laying down their lives, they killed many times more than their numbers.

Yadav is among the handful of survivors who will commemorate the 45th anniversary of the battle on November 18. He has spent the last few weeks traversing a yatra through the martyrs' villages, telling people a story of unparalleled bravery and sacrifice. In fact members of the Rezang La Shaurya Samiti (RLSS), that was formed in 1983 to honour the families of the martyrs of Rezang La and other soldiers, visited the valley in June to bring back the soil of a battle that has gone down in the annals of world military history as a saga of supreme sacrifice and bravery.

The yatra was flagged off from Delhi by General Deepak Kapoor, a few days before he took over as the Chief of the Army Staff. Carrying the soil of Rezang La in an urn, it has



now covered nearly two-thirds of the villages. Four soldiers who survived the Chinese assault recount incidents and anecdotes from the battle to the kith and kin of those who laid down their lives.

Company commander Major Shaitan Singh Bhati got the Param Veer Chakra, eight others were awarded the Veer Chakra while four sol-

diers got the Sena Medals for what is also known as the battle of Chushul. The Rezang La post has been renamed Ahir Dham as 57 soldiers came from the Ahirwal region of Haryana. Nineteen were from Rajasthan, 25 from Uttar Pradesh and one each from Madhya Pradesh and Punjab.

RLSS also hands over Kisan Vikas Patras amounting to Rs 5,000 to one girl child of the martyrs' dependants. Secretary of RLSS Naresh Chauhan says, "the third round of the yatra would be held after November 18."

The Ahirwal region has been fighting for another cause for over 25 years. The region has around 42,000 former soldiers and nearly 26,000 serving soldiers and yearns for a *sainik school*. Captain Ram Chandra says, "the then defence minister, R. Venkatraman, had in 1983 promised a *sainik school* which has not materialised till date. This year we will celebrate another anniversary—the government's silver jubilee of the announcement of the still-awaited school." ■